

Caught in a TIME WARP

Sporadic empirical data and a blinkered view mar the outpourings of a brilliant mind



THE CAGED PHOENIX: CAN INDIA FLY?

by DIPANKAR GUPTA

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| By Chandan Mitra |

The eminent professor, Dipankar Gupta, has at least one admirable trait: he is brutally honest about his intentions. Thus, he sums up his mission in writing this voluminous monograph quite candidly: "I think the intellectual can contribute meaningfully to a country's development by advocating an academic perspective that is always on the lookout for something to criticise. If we succeed then we will have damaged, if not demolished, every ivory tower in the vicinity." This cerebrally violent mindset naturally leads to rampant iconoclasm, often without good enough reason. If a thinker has predetermined that everything that he sees around him is an "ivory tower" that deserves to be smashed, it is understandable that he will end up tilting at windmills in the fashion of Don Quixote, while his icon-bashing zeal would approximate that of Mahmud of Ghazni or Kalapahad.

Gupta finds little that is good or commendable about India's post-Independence economic and social development. He sets out to find loopholes everywhere because he insists that 77 per cent of the population lives on an earning of \$2 per day (a debatable statistic); the middle class is a myth; and the IT boom is statistical jugglery since a mere three million are employed in that sector. At the same time, he approvingly refers to B.R. Ambedkar's description of the Indian village as a cesspool of degradation, corruption and worse. Hence the Indian phoenix is a caged bird not ready to fly. The book is a somewhat meandering compilation of sporadic empirical data collected at the grass-roots, interspersed with lengthy treatises outlining reasons for India's abject failure to pursue egalitarian objectives. It is regrettable that such an eminent social anthropologist failed to capture the

significant changes that have swept across the Indian countryside in the last couple of decades.

Compounded by preordained notions and the fixated view that politicians are necessarily "bad", he sweepingly asserts that far from reaching out to indebted farmers, many of whom have been driven to suicide, "many leading politicians are labelling suicide victims as 'mad'." Curiously, the author attributes this remark to a well known publicist of rural poverty, P. Sainath, who allegedly made this claim in a lecture in 2006. It may be my rank ignorance, but I have never come across any politician calling farmers who commit suicide 'mad'. They wouldn't dare, because politicians need farmers to vote for them.

Gupta is particularly dismissive about the quantity and quality of the Indian middle class. His self-proclaimed mission to demolish every "ivory tower" is reinforced by his rather carping assessment of the huge spurt in cellphone ownership. He says even unskilled or semi-skilled workers carry mobile phones because these are their lifeline to gainful employment. So, even if many cellphone owners survive at subsistence levels, they still invest in this gadget. The possession of a mobile phone, he says, does not signify a person's entry into the middle class category. But whoever said that?

On the whole, the book does not make a significant contribution to academic exploration of the contemporary Indian model. The negative streak is so overpowering that even those poverty-peddlers who might be tempted to agree with Gupta's broad thesis, would probably conclude that the author is too blinkered. Some newspaper analysts would find the book handy to embellish their outdated socialist arguments. But as a regular reader of his columns, I feel his articles make much more incisive reading. ■



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